

JOHNBOLDINGVOXEDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we are at the World Travel Market in London. It's the place where all the travel industry get together and exchange ideas, tell everyone about their products. I have with me John Boulding from Vox, V-O-X, Italy.

And John, welcome to the program. Yeah, thank you very much. It's a pleasure to be with you, Geoff.

And Vox is a fantastic company. You provide tech for tour guides around the world. This is a really fascinating area.

And you were telling me last night, it's incredible tech because if there's a tour guide, they can be speaking to on their headsets to multiple people in different languages with AI. It's an incredible use of AI. Yeah, it is.

Things have moved so far. And it's all to do with the large language models that have developed the capability of doing very, very fast and accurate and in context translation. And so what we've done is to develop far beyond the smartphone application that everybody knows that Google can do translation and so on.

We've moved far beyond that and put this technology into radios. And that's a really important difference because one of the problems that you have using smartphones is connectivity. So often, a group traveling, for example, will have kids with them.

They may not have a smartphone. They'll have somebody who's got a legacy smartphone rather than one of the latest models that doesn't really have the capability to receive that type of transmission data. You'll find somebody's forgotten their earphones or whatever.

So we know about group operations. That's our specialist area. And we know that the technology that works is radios because they're fully charged.

They're ready to go. They come with the earpiece, and you simply plug it in, select your language channel, and away you go. And what we've done is to build that bridge.

So we have this very smart device, I have to say, that connects to the internet via SIM card or via Wi-Fi. And that alone has the connection to get the translations done. It's all in context, special algorithms that look at the context of the conversation that's happening and therefore provide a much more accurate rendition of the language in the language of the user.

So it's pretty cool. Now, to give an example of this, for the non-techie people that are listening to this thinking, oh, this is all a bit complicated, for an example, I would imagine there's a tour guide showing a group of people around the Colosseum in Rome, and that might be 20, 30 people of all different nationalities. And these people can just choose the language that the host or the guide is

speaking in, and they will get that pretty much one second later or whatever in real time in their own language.

Yes, that's correct, yeah. Latency is, it's called latency if something's, a delay is called a latency. And it's really very quick.

It's like a live translator. If you had someone standing next to you who was listening to your guide and then translating it into your language, what they would have to do as a human is listen to the context and then translate. And this is exactly the same process.

So you're right, Jeff. In simple terms, that's what's happening. So it's incredible technology and what all this happens in maybe one or two seconds, basically.

Yeah, correct. Absolutely. Yeah.

And of course, once it starts, the thing with this technology, unlike a human, as it's giving you the translation, it's already listening to the next part of the conversation and already dealing with that. So once the stream starts, it's continuous. You get a continuous conversation coming.

So it's very exciting. Well, there's literally tens of thousands, if not hundreds of thousands, tour guides around the world who this Vox technology, VOX, is just fantastic for them. And they can contact you and you can set up a whole system with them with the transmitters, receivers, all that sort of thing.

And I imagine it's very cost effective as well. Yes, it is. And it's used in Australia too.

I mean, it is literally around the world. We work with over 150 countries supplying this technology in all the key places that your listeners are going to be going to. But one of the really important things, let's look beyond the technology for a moment and talk about what is the effect of all of this.

You know, today's world is so much of scrolling. You know, you've got your smartphone and you're scrolling through all the images that you see of all the fabulous destinations. But what that's doing is enticing people to actually go and really experience it for themselves.

Certainly Generation Z or Zed, as we would say, they do this all the time. You know, they're looking at their phones, but what they actually want is real human contact, real experiences. And I think one of the barriers to real understanding has been language.

That's the biggest barrier of all, because it's so hard for someone who doesn't have other languages to communicate with a visitor. And this tool becomes a bridge. It's not replacing humans.

It's supplementing and complementing and helping the experience grow into something where

there's real understanding. And if you've got real understanding, then all of a sudden the visitor and the community that you're visiting come together, you know, both benefiting. And the fact that both benefit from this, that's real sustainability.

We talk about plastics and carbon and everything else, but I think real sustainability, the core of it is this shared benefit that we get from the exciting world of travel. I travel all around Europe and America and Australia. Oftentimes when I'm in a place, it's very normal now to someone to pull out their phone and say, speak into this, and it will tell me in my own language what you're talking about.

Now to us when we were growing up, that was Star Trek stuff, right? And that's just so normal now. And in 10 years, this world is going to be a completely different place to what it is now. We're going to look back on 2025 tech-wise and say it was so simple back then, right? Yeah.

Yeah, no, absolutely. Interestingly, I think, really, really interestingly, COVID for us as a tech company has been the real accelerator, the real quantum leap moment when even older people, I'm older myself, I'm a boomer. Same here.

Yeah. And we started using technology in a way that we never had before. QR codes were suddenly used by everybody.

We were using smartphones to communicate with the grandkids or the kids or whatever. Suddenly, everybody was using technology. And that coming out of COVID is how this quantum step has happened, this huge leap forward.

I saw something on TikTok the other day. They had a bunch of teenagers trying to explain to their granddad from 2025, who's now in his maybe early 20s, that, hey, granddad, you don't need the handheld device. You just blink and things are in your eyes.

I mean, 10 years, this world's going to be a completely different place because, as you say, the technology is moving fast, so go forward so far. Yeah, it is. And I think the benefits until now of travel have often been a first world thing.

But what I see now is that local communities, it might be in Africa, a village in Ghana, the elders there can share what are oral histories about their community, probably not written down anywhere. And therefore, were never being passed on. But now with this can communicate to visitors and so on.

So I think, you know, this is opening up travel in a way that's never been opened up before. It's a very exciting moment. And the great thing about it is that it's audio.

And as we know, audio via podcasts, radio is just exploding across the world. And the great thing about audio is you're not a slave to your vision to a device. You can walk around somewhere and have something in your ears which is tremendous.

And I said a lot of people, someone said to me today, do you think radio is dying? I said, I think this is just the dawn of radio transmissions and that kind of content delivery system. Yeah, we've done research on radio for various reasons, whether it's advertising or whatever. And certainly I believe that the success rate of businesses using radio is at least 40% higher than businesses that don't.

So, you know, that's really true. And that is our business is audio in a travel environment. Exactly.

You can do so many things with things in your ears that you're not. You can be running, taking a shower, driving, doing all sorts of things. And you cannot always have that.

Well, John, it's been fascinating. John Balding from Vox in Italy. It's been fascinating speaking to you about this brilliant new tech world.

And John, how can people find out more about Vox online? Right. So you can go to voxtours.com and you'll see what we do. We're largely a business that works with other businesses.

We support them. So if your tour operator is one that you think could be using something like this, let them know that there is a solution that we can help with. So that would be absolutely great.

But we'd love to support all Australians traveling. It's a very big market for us generally. I lived in Australia back in 1977, Jeff, actually, a long time ago.

But I tell you what, Australians are some of the best travelers in the world. So good on you guys. Well, when we travel, when we travel, we do the whole world.

We have to because you might as well. Right. Absolutely true.

Thanks very much. What a pleasure to talk to you. Thank you.